

AI Agents with M365 Copilot

Workshop for *researchers*



Introduction

What is an AI Agent?

Etymology

Agent comes from *Agere* (Latin) “to do”; so does *Act*.

- Most GenAI use is confined to a ‘chat’:
 - I say, you say
- AI Agents can **act**
 - I say, you **do**

Define agents with custom information / behaviour

Your own ‘custom’ AIs

Different types of agents

M365-style

Application-integrated

Behind-the-scenes

Agents in Microsoft 365 Copilot

According to Microsoft [1] (emphasis added):

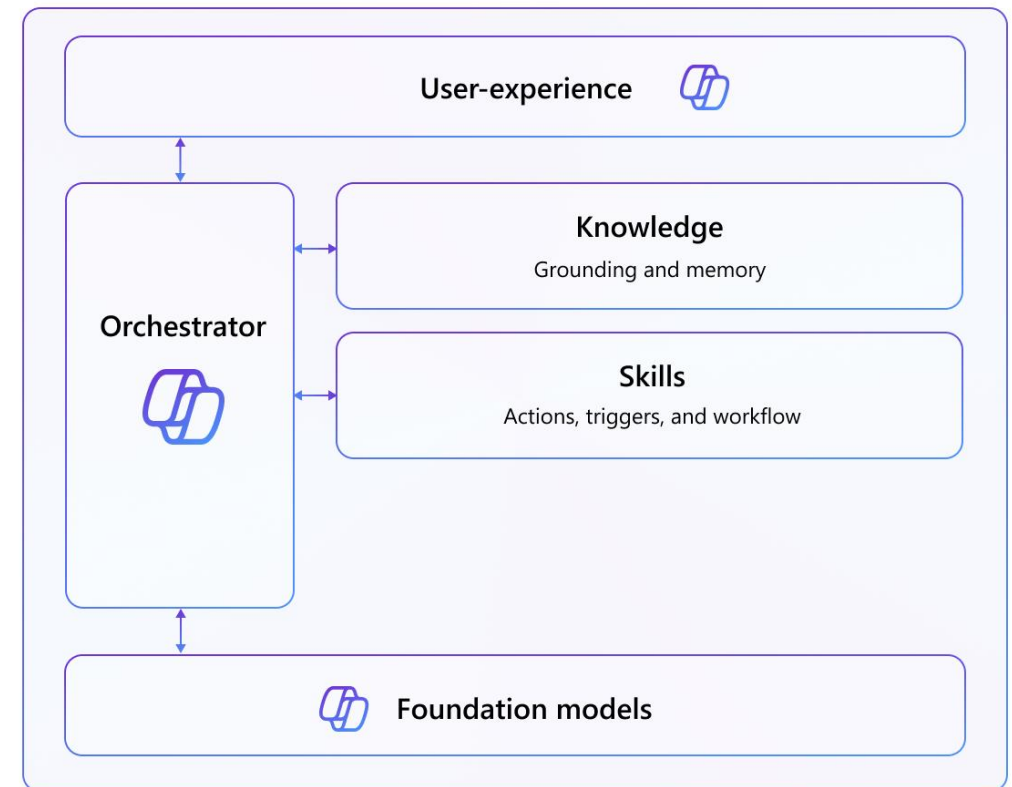
*Agents extend the functionality of Copilot by acting as specialized AI assistants tailored to **specific domains**.*

*These agents **apply organizational knowledge** and automation to streamline business processes, enhance decision making, and improve efficiency.*

*Agents can **retrieve information**, summarize data, or even **take actions** like sending emails or updating records.*

Why M365? We have a licence at UQ.

Anatomy of
Declarative agent



[1] <https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365/copilot/extensibility/agents-overview>

Agents in Microsoft 365 Copilot

What can / can't our M365 agents do?

Can

Chat

Inform agent with specific or all websites

Create

- Images
- Code
- Word/Excel/PPT files

Can't

Read emails or Teams chats

- *Can* access some details about recent emails and collaborators

Integrate with other software

Act proactively / behind-the-scenes

These features *are* available if you upgrade (\$\$\$)

Agents in Microsoft 365 Copilot

Agent Builder Options

Title and description

Don't overlook these – behaviour takes them into account!

Instructions

Provide all details here. Being vague yields a general agent, specific yields a specialised one. Include

- Purpose / object / mission
- Context / relationship to you
- Tone / style
- Rules / guidelines

Model

Auto, Quick response, Think deeper

Knowledge

Draw information from internet? Specific URLs? Only?

- URLs limited to 'two levels deep'
- Can upload files to individual chats *later*

Capabilities

Can create Word / Excel / PPT files, code and images

Suggested prompts

Quick ways to start a chat with this agent

Research Assistant

Example 1

Building the agent

Start from a prompt

Allow “search all websites”

Prompts to try

I’m currently researching [xyz]. Provide me a survey of the literature and output the result as a Word document. Format as a list of sources with a one sentence summary of each.

Produce some sample data from an [xyz] study/experiment as an Excel file, and then provide a Python script that analyses it. Show me the graphs.

Subject matter expert

Example 2

Building the agent

Start from scratch

Add any websites you think are relevant

Prompts to try

Given your expertise, critique my upcoming report on [xyz].

There is disagreement in the literature between [x] and [y]. Can you provide an overview with some advice on the intersection with [z]?

Presentation coach

Example 3

Building the agent

From prompt

Prompt to update instructions

Prompts to consider

Suggest a framework for a 3-minute thesis talk on [xyz].

Here are my slides for an upcoming talk – how can I improve them?

Critique my presentation

- Can't upload recording, but can upload a transcript.
Surprisingly good!

Generate a good title image for my talk on [xyz]

- Explore the image editor

DIY agent

Your turn!

Come up with an agent that is relevant to you and try create it

Some ideas

- Note taker / summariser
- Admin assistant
- Graphic designer
- Language tutor

Spend some time, then share your outcomes!

Contact

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